

Chapter Two: Two Coffees and One Interview.

Mia woke me the next morning by opening the curtains.

Sunlight hit my face so suddenly that I pulled the blanket over my head.

“Get up, Ana,” Mia said. “We have work to do.”

“It’s Saturday,” I mumbled beneath the blanket.

“Unemployed people don’t have weekends.”

I lowered the blanket and stared at her.

“That was unnecessarily cruel,” I said.

“It was also accurate,” Mia replied.

I reached for my phone on the bedside table.

It was nine twenty-three.

There were four messages from Mama, two from Jun, and one from Aunt Flor asking whether I had met any unmarried men during graduation.

I opened Jun’s messages first.

Send me your CV before noon. I’ll check it.

His second message had arrived twenty minutes later.

And don’t use the version with your picture in the corner.

I sat up.

“What is wrong with my picture?” I asked.

Mia was standing in front of the mirror, tying her hair.

“You look like the police took that picture after questioning you,” Mia replied.

“I thought I looked professional.”

“You looked frightened.”

“I was trying not to smile.”

“You succeeded.”

I picked up a pillow and threw it at her.

Mia moved aside. The pillow fell onto the floor.

“We’re going to the café,” Mia announced.

“Why?”

“You work better there.”

“I work perfectly well at home.”

Mia turned away from the mirror.

“The last time you worked on your CV at home, you reorganized the kitchen drawers.”

“They needed organizing.”

“You arranged the spoons according to size.”

“That is normal.”

“You also made a separate section for spoons you considered emotionally reliable.”

“I was stressed.”

“Exactly,” Mia said. “Get dressed.”

Before leaving the bed, I checked my bank account.

I had enough money for groceries, transport, and part of the electricity bill. The rest of the month depended on careful planning, cheap meals, and avoiding my landlord whenever I heard him in the hallway.

“We cannot spend much today,” I warned Mia.

“One coffee each,” Mia replied.

“No cake.”

Mia looked at me through the mirror.

“You graduated yesterday.”

“And I’m still broke today.”

“That degree changed nothing.”

I stared at her.

“Thank you,” I said. “That was very encouraging.”

“I meant financially.”

“That was the part I understood.”

The café was a ten-minute walk from our apartment.

It was small, quiet, and slightly more expensive than it had any right to be. The chairs did not match, the tables were too close together, and every drink came in a cup that looked too small for its price.

Mia loved the place.

More specifically, she loved Table Seven.

It stood beside the front window, where the morning light came in without becoming too hot. It was also far enough from the counter for Mia to complain about the staff without lowering her voice.

When we entered, a young man was already sitting there.

He had spread his laptop, notebooks, phone charger, and several sheets of paper across the table.

Mia stopped walking.

“He is sitting at our table,” Mia said.

“It is not our table,” I replied.

“We sit there every Saturday.”

“That does not make it ours.”

“It creates an understanding.”

“An understanding with whom?”

“The café.”

“The café has never spoken to us.”

“That is not my fault.”

Several other tables were empty.

I pointed toward one near the wall.

“We can sit there,” I suggested.

Mia looked at the table and shook her head.

“No.”

“Why not?”

“The lighting is terrible.”

“We are editing my CV, Mia. We are not taking wedding pictures.”

Mia stared at the man sitting at Table Seven.

“Ask him to move,” she said.

“I am not asking a stranger to move.”

“He is one person using four chairs.”

“He was here first.”

“You lack leadership.”

“You lack shame.”

The young man looked up from his laptop.

I smiled at him awkwardly and walked toward the table near the wall.

Mia followed me, muttering about the decline of public manners.

Ben was working behind the counter.

He had worked at the café for almost a year. He was quiet, polite, and always looked as though he was thinking about something more important than the conversation happening in front of him.

He already knew our order.

“The usual two?” Ben asked when I approached the counter.

“Yes, please,” I replied.

“One hot Americano and one iced caramel latte?”

“Less ice,” Mia called from our table.

I looked over my shoulder.

“I know,” I told her.

Ben paused with one hand above the register.

“Sorry?” he asked.

I turned back to him.

“Nothing,” I said. “I was just reminding myself. Less ice in the caramel latte, please.”

Ben nodded and entered the order.

“And one slice of banana cake?” he asked.

“No cake today.”

“Ana,” Mia called.

I ignored her.

Ben glanced toward the table but did not say anything.

“Just the two coffees?” Ben asked.

“Yes.”

“One slice of banana cake,” Mia insisted.

I turned toward her.

“We cannot afford cake,” I said.

The café became strangely quiet.

The man at Table Seven looked up again.

Ben kept his eyes on the register.

“Would you like the cake?” Ben asked carefully.

I closed my eyes for a moment.

“Yes,” I said. “One slice.”

Mia smiled.

“And a separate plate,” Mia added.

“No separate plate,” I replied.

Ben looked at me.

“One fork?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“Two forks,” Mia said.

“One is fine,” I told Ben.

Ben completed the order.

“That will be three hundred and eighty pesos,” he said.

I stared at the amount on the screen.

“Three hundred and eighty?”

“The cake is one hundred and forty,” Ben explained.

I looked toward Mia.

She had picked up the menu and was pretending not to notice me.

“Please remove the cake,” I told Ben.

Ben removed it without showing any irritation.

“No problem,” he said.

“Ana,” Mia complained from the table.

I lowered my voice.

“I have an electricity bill,” I reminded her.

Ben handed me the receipt.

I carried it back to our table.

Mia folded her arms.

“You embarrassed me,” she said.

“You ordered food using my money.”

“You could have said no quietly.”

“I did say no quietly. You ignored me.”

“You are tense.”

“I have a job interview on Monday and almost no money left.”

“You have more than no money.”

“After I pay the electricity bill, I will have six hundred pesos.”

“Then don’t pay the whole bill.”

“That is not how bills work.”

“You pay some now and some later.”

“That is why I already have three notices.”

Mia looked down at the table.

“I only wanted to celebrate your graduation,” she said.

I felt guilty immediately.

Mia had a special talent for creating a problem and then making me feel cruel for noticing it.

“I’ll buy cake after the interview,” I promised.

Mia looked at me.

“After you get the job,” she corrected me.

“That could take weeks.”

“Then we will have earned it.”

Ben approached with our drinks.

He placed the Americano in front of me and the iced caramel latte on the opposite side of the table.

“Thank you,” I said.

“You’re welcome,” Ben replied.

Mia picked up her latte and stirred it with the straw.

Ben remained beside the table for a moment.

“Are you working on another university assignment?” he asked.

“No,” I replied. “I have an interview on Monday.”

Ben smiled.

“That’s good. Congratulations.”

“Thank you.”

“What kind of job?”

“Junior communications assistant.”

Mia leaned forward.

“Junior strategy and communications assistant,” Mia corrected me.

I looked at her.

“That title is unnecessarily long,” I said.

Ben glanced around the café.

“What?” he asked.

I turned back to him.

“I said the job title is unnecessarily long.”

Ben nodded.

“A lot of job titles are,” he said. “They make simple work sound expensive.”

Mia pointed at him.

“That is the first intelligent thing he has said,” she whispered.

I ignored her.

Ben looked toward the laptop in front of me.

“Are you preparing your answers?” he asked.

“I’m trying to.”

“She is avoiding it,” Mia said.

“I am not avoiding it,” I replied.

Ben looked confused.

“I didn’t say you were.”

I cleared my throat.

“I know,” I said. “I was talking to Mia.”

Ben’s eyes moved briefly toward the chair across from me.

Mia was sitting there, drinking her coffee.

“Right,” Ben said.

He returned to the counter.

I watched him walk away.

“That was strange,” I said.

Mia took another sip from her latte.

“What was strange?”

“The way he looked at you.”

“He is always strange.”

“No, he isn’t.”

“He has the personality of plain rice.”

“He is just quiet.”

“Quiet people notice too much.”

“He asked about my interview.”

“He was listening to our conversation.”

“He works here. We were speaking near him.”

“That does not give him permission to become involved in our lives.”

I opened my laptop.

“Can we focus?”

Mia moved her drink away from the computer.

“Fine,” she replied. “Show me your CV.”

I opened the document.

Mia leaned across the table and read the first paragraph.

“Delete the objective,” she said.

“Why?”

“It says you are looking for a challenging position where you can learn and grow.”

“That is normal.”

“It sounds like you are applying to become a plant.”

“It means I want to improve.”

“Everybody says that. Write something confident.”

“Such as?”

Mia thought for a moment.

“Experienced professional with a proven history of excellence.”

“I do not have a proven history of excellence.”

“You graduated.”

“Yesterday.”

“They do not need every detail.”

“I’m applying for an entry-level position.”

“Never describe yourself as entry-level.”

“That is the actual job.”

“Entry-level means they want experience but do not want to pay for it.”

I stared at her.

“That is probably the most accurate thing you have said today.”

“Thank you.”

“It was not a compliment.”

I scrolled down to my work-experience section.

I had listed my previous part-time jobs: cashier, reception assistant, online seller, and temporary office clerk.

Mia read each one carefully.

“You need to make these sound more important,” she said.

“I cannot lie.”

“You are not lying. You are improving the vocabulary.”

Mia pointed to my cashier job.

“Instead of ‘handled customer payments,’ write ‘managed daily financial transactions.’”

I considered the sentence.

“That sounds reasonable,” I admitted.

“For your online selling, write ‘operated an independent digital retail business.’”

“I sold second-hand clothes.”

“Did you sell them online?”

“Yes.”

“Did you work independently?”

“Yes.”

“Was it retail?”

“Technically.”

Mia smiled.

“Then you were a businesswoman.”

I typed the sentence.

Jun did not need to know about that part.

We spent almost an hour revising my CV.

Mia rejected every sentence that sounded uncertain. I rejected every sentence that made me sound like the owner of an international company.

When we finished, I sent the document to Jun.

He replied three minutes later.

Did Mia help you with this?

I showed the message to her.

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“How did he know?” I asked.

“Because it is excellent,” Mia replied.

Another message arrived.

‘Independent digital retail business’ means the old clothes you sold online, right?

I placed my phone facedown on the table.

“He does not respect me.”

“He knows you too well.”

“That is worse.”

Mia pulled a notebook toward her.

“Let’s practise the interview,” she said.

“Here?”

“Yes.”

“There are people around.”

“Nobody cares.”

The man at Table Seven was still working. Two students were sitting near the door. Ben was wiping the counter.

I lowered my voice.

“Fine,” I said.

Mia sat straighter.

“I will be the interviewer,” she announced.

“You are already enjoying this.”

Mia ignored me.

“Good morning, Ana,” she began. “Tell me about yourself.”

I froze.

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Mia waited.

“Well?” she asked.

“I’m thinking.”

“You have had forty years.”

“That question is too broad.”

“It is usually the first question.”

“I know. That is why I hate it.”

“Just answer.”

I took a breath.

“My name is Ana Lim. I recently completed my degree in business communication—”

Mia raised one hand.

“I already know your name,” she interrupted. “It is written on your application.”

“You told me to introduce myself.”

“I did not tell you to read your birth certificate.”

I leaned back in my chair.

“This is not helping.”

“It will help.”

“Ask another question.”

Mia looked down at the notebook.

“What is your greatest weakness?” she asked.

“I overthink.”

“Too honest.”

“I struggle with public speaking.”

“They may need you to speak in public.”

“I sometimes take on too much responsibility.”

Mia nodded.

“Good. That is a respectable fake weakness.”

“It is true.”

“When have you ever taken on too much responsibility?”

“I pay the full rent.”

“That is financial irresponsibility, not leadership.”

I stared at her.

“Next question.”

Mia continued.

“Why should we hire you?”

“Because I am hardworking, willing to learn, and—”

“Boring,” Mia interrupted.

“What do you want me to say?”

“Tell them you are mature, reliable, and better prepared for pressure than someone who has never had to choose between paying for electricity and buying shampoo.”

“I cannot say that in an interview.”

“You should. It shows decision-making.”

“Which one did I choose?”

“Electricity.”

“No. I bought shampoo.”

Mia shrugged.

“Then it shows personal hygiene.”

Someone laughed behind me.

I turned around.

Ben was carrying a tray of empty cups. He looked away quickly.

“Were you listening?” I asked.

“No,” Ben replied.

“You laughed.”

“One of the students said something.”

The two students near the door were both silent.

Ben glanced at them, then looked back at me.

“Maybe the sound came from outside,” he said.

Mia shook her head.

“He is a terrible liar,” she whispered.

Ben collected an empty cup from the next table.

“I wasn’t trying to listen,” he said. “But the part about being mature and reliable was good.”

“You heard that?”

“Only some of it.”

“You don’t think it sounds desperate?”

“No,” Ben replied. “Just don’t mention the shampoo.”

I laughed.

“Thank you.”

Ben nodded and returned to the counter.

Mia watched him walk away.

“He likes you,” she said.

“He gave me interview advice.”

“Men do not give free advice without a motive.”

“Jun gives me advice every day.”

“Jun is your brother. Even he wants control of your CV.”

I closed my laptop.

“We are not discussing Ben.”

Mia smiled.

“You know his name.”

“It is written on his name tag.”

“You noticed.”

“I can read.”

Mia smiled into her coffee.

I reached for my Americano and discovered the cup was empty.

Mia’s caramel latte was still almost full.

“You barely drank this,” I said.

“I had some.”

“You always leave most of it.”

“I changed my mind.”

“You insisted on coming here.”

“I came for the atmosphere.”

“You could order water.”

“That would be embarrassing.”

“More embarrassing than ordering coffee you do not drink?”

“Yes.”

I pulled Mia’s cup toward me.

The ice had melted, but the drink was still cold.

“You’re going to finish it?” Mia asked.

“I paid for it.”

“You complain every time.”

“And I finish it every time.”

“That sounds like a personal choice.”

I took a long sip.

At the counter, Ben looked toward our table.

When our eyes met, he turned toward the coffee machine.

“He is watching us again,” I said.

Mia glanced toward the counter.

“No, he isn’t.”

“He just looked at our table.”

“He looked at you.”

“Stop.”

“I am only saying what I saw.”

I packed my laptop into my bag.

“Tomorrow, we practise again at home.”

“Why at home?”

“Because you insult me less when there are witnesses.”

“That is not true.”

“It is completely true.”

Mia stood and pushed her chair back.

“Are we leaving?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“What about the cake?”

“There is no cake.”

“I know. I’m still upset.”

I carried both empty cups to the counter.

Ben looked at them.

“Finished both again?” he asked.

I smiled.

“Mia never finishes hers,” I explained.

Ben’s eyes moved briefly toward our table.

Mia was standing beside the door, waiting for me.

“Right,” Ben said.

“See you next week,” I told him.

“Good luck on Monday,” Ben replied.

“Thank you.”

As we left the café, Mia slipped her arm through mine.

“He definitely likes you,” she said.

“You did not even speak to him.”

“He kept looking at our table.”

“Maybe he thinks we are strange.”

Mia looked offended.

“Speak for yourself.”

“You made me order two coffees and tried to buy cake when I could not afford it.”

“And your CV is now better.”

“That has nothing to do with coffee.”

“Everything is connected, Ana.”

“That does not mean anything.”

“It sounded wise.”

Outside, the afternoon sun had become stronger.

We walked slowly toward our apartment while Mia explained how I should enter the interview room, where I should place my hands, and why I should never accept a glass of water in case my nervous shaking became visible.

For the first time since receiving the interview invitation, I felt slightly less afraid.

I was not prepared.

I was definitely not confident.

But I was less afraid.

For now, that was enough.